South Marston
Parish Council

18/9/2024

South Marston Parish Council Response to S/RES/24/0947: Parcels R6 & 7

Preamble: Connected applications for Phase 1 South Marston expansion

The 'live' applications by Taylor Wimpey parcels 8 and 9, Vistry for parcels 6 and 7 and the Primary Street applications are linked via the shared reliance on pedestrian and cycling connectivity, the provision and adequacy of SUDs provision and the timing of delivery.

Furthermore, all 3 applications are reliant on delivery of other essential infrastructure for which no detailed plans are yet available. This includes Strategic Utilities provision across the South Marston expansion and the Cycle and Pedestrian routes through the Strategic Green Infrastructure that surrounds their respective red lines.

It is not possible to determine the sustainability of the three live applications without placing a caveat on the need for timely delivery of the missing Reserved Matters.

We note in particular:

- **Phasing Plan** (approved Aug 2023) page 17 and **CADC-1** Movement Sequencing (approved August 2024) states that footpaths and cycleways in the strategic open space between housing parcels do not need to be delivered until 95% occupancy of the relevant Phase. Regardless of the interpretation of 'phase', the result is that the vast majority of occupants in Phase 1 will have not have access to <u>any</u> safe pedestrian and cycle routes into or out of the expanded village for several years.

  This is contrary to the South Marston Neighbourhood Plan which laid emphasis on delivering a significant reduction in the need for vehicle use.

- **Utilities Infrastructure:** The SBC Highways response to early versions of Reserved Matters concerning delivery of the Haul Road/Primary Street noted that delivery of the Haul Road should consider installing appropriate ducting under the road for utilities to avoid being dug up at a later date. There is no such provision for utilities infrastructure on the current Primary Street application S/RES/24/1020.

  Since parcels R6 and R7 straddle the Primary Street, preparation for utilities delivery must be taken into account.

We appreciate that tackling this expansion by means of individual parcels means better focus on the detail of each. However, the fault lines between parcels are rapidly becoming clear and we assert that any approval of Reserved Matters applications should require those to be remedied before construction starts.

S/RES/24/0947 Vistry Parcels R6 and R7

South Marston Parish Council comments as follows:

Having talked directly to the Vistry architect and planner, we believe that the whole approach lacks an appreciation of how this parcel's development sits within its immediate surroundings, the impact of the piecemeal provision of essential infrastructure and the need for the design to relate to the wider expanded village.

Their consideration of layout etc relies heavily on the neighbouring green infrastructure and design of the footpaths and cycleways it contains. A primary example of this is the Vistry R6 which has no safe pedestrian/cycle route out of the red line area until other applications are submitted and agreed and 95% of a phase is occupied (see **Phasing Plan** and **CADC-1 Movement Sequencing**).

We would hope that Borough Officers see the relevance of safe cycleway/pedestrian access out of the red line area for each of these applications before 95% occupancy is achieved.

- **Layout of R7**

  Given the shape of this parcel, options for the layout area minimal. We have a concern about lack of safe pedestrian access for the dwellings fronting onto Old Vicarage Lane which has no footway and the absence of a direct route to the school.

- **Overall concept layout of R6**

  We have serious concerns about the very cramped layout in R6. From direct liaison with Wimpey architect and Chief Planner, we understand the layout is a direct result of the concept in the CADC-1 for less dense housing on all boundaries to the exclusion of all other factors. Whilst we have no objection to this as a generic principle, it is responsible for resulting in a boundary of big open market housing on the outskirts, 5 hammerhead junctions at the end of multiple cul de sacs and an unacceptably crowded ghetto at the centre. We do not believe blind adherence to the CADC general principle, which does not impose a specific road layout, should lead to a layout that is, in our view, completely unacceptable.

- **Road Layout within R6**

  The road layout is in conflict with the **South Marston Neighbourhood Plan Policy NP4** which states *'Large cul de sacs…. will be discouraged'*. We would add that the profusion of cul de sacs each ending in turning spaces, also lacks the required legibility in navigating within this parcel.

  The 'ghetto' in the centre (the main affordable housing area) has no visitor parking anywhere near, emphasizing its cramped nature.

  On the main left turn entry to the parcel from the Primary Street, views are dominated by a long, virtually continuous run of parallel car parking in front of the dwellings. The interspersed street trees appear to be planted in concrete since there is no internal green infrastructure or other landscaping/verges so would not deliver the required 'filtering' of views under the parking requirements of CADC-1.

- **Potential for a better layout**

  We consider that there are good reasons why the general principle of less dense housing on the southern boundary of R6 should be reconsidered. This is the area most affected by railway noise (see CADC-1) and where housing mass may be appropriate. The Vistry planner indicates that the

noise level is such that it is not an over-riding issue in the design, but it is still something that should be considered, particularly if an alternative offers additional benefits.

We have stated in previous responses that we would not object to 2.5 storey buildings on this boundary, and particularly if that enables two dwellings on the same footprint. The latter may provide the ability to distribute the affordable housing more evenly around the site. Nor would we object to semi-detached housing which offers better options in removing parallel parking from the frontage of houses internal to the parcel. It also distributes visitor parking more evenly between open market and affordable housing.

- **Parking**

We already experience problems with new build estate and insufficient ad hoc parking provision, particularly with the increase in online deliveries. We are acutely aware that South Marston expanded village will still be very much a car-borne community – we have no guarantee of a bus service running through the village.

In new estates, the road widths and frontage parking on dwelling plots severely limit the safe potential for ad hoc roadside parking which we have elsewhere in the village. With multiple similar housing parcels south of the village, the only potential ad hoc parking we have is along the Primary Street verges/kerbs, on some of the rural stretches of secondary roads and Bridleway 4.

We are concerned about the overall amount available and would ask that Borough Officers check that it is judged adequate in the light of the above. Visitor parking in R6 at the moment is on the external boundaries of the site, with none close to the affordable housing.

Bearing in mind that affordable housing should be tenure blind not just in terms of design, but also availability of parking, this is inappropriate. The 'ghetto' design means visitors are inside the central 'allocated parking area' before they find there is no space to park. Our suggestion of a more distributed layout of affordable housing would avoid this.

- **Street Scene (R6 and R7)**

We dislike the standard colour palette and identical roof lines along street views. This is not in keeping with the Taylor Wimpey R8 and R9 design nor with the rest of the village and it lacks legibility. We believe building design should complement neighbouring design, not impose a uniformity that adds to the feeling that the external facing dwellings 'enclose' the parcel, particularly if the central area looks like a ghetto dominated by parked cars.

- **Safe Access for pedestrians and cyclists**

There is no safe pedestrian and cycle access out of the red line to the school at all until the remainder of the Primary Street is completed up to western edge of the Taylor Wimpey site. The timing of that is not determined by this application.

Access to the local school and Village Centre relies on the surfaced routes across the intervening green infrastructure being fit for purpose in connecting with Carpenters Walk, but those plans are not yet available and trigger points for delivery may make this very late in the occupation process.

No pedestrian links are provided to access the Carpenters Walk route to the Village Hall/School internally or at the northern boundary of the site.

In terms of wider connectivity, R6 and R7 will, according to the agreed Phasing Plan, have no safe cycle access out of the village (acknowledged to be a key sustainability factor) until at least 95% of the whole build phase is occupied.

Even then, there are only two potential off-road cycleway routes that could be provided:

- The Primary Street cycleway, which leads only to the railway footbridge with no guarantee that the ramps or link to the A420 on third party land will be delivered even after 300 houses are occupied. Note the Primary Street approach to Thornhill Road will not carry an adjacent cycleway.
- The Bridleway 4 route to Morses Lane, where the junction with Thornhill Rd was deemed 'unsafe', but could be improved via the separately planned SBC traffic calming initiative and reduced speed limit

Note For R7, Old Vicarage Lane is not a safe cycle or walking route as it has no roadside footway so dwellings fronting OVL do not have safe routes. The Carpenters Arms bridge at the A420 junction has been judged by SBC Highways Officers as not suitable for walkers or cyclists.

We need the Borough and the developers to tell us just what is the appropriate safe route for cyclists out of the village for the first 300 occupiers of Phase 1 South Marston.

- **Future Maintenance of Green Infrastructure**

  Following discussions with Vistry senior management, we are negotiating on the potential for South Marston Parish Council to take on the eventual management of green infrastructure. Within the FLEAMP, Section 6 specifically identifies that maintenance will be handed over to a management company. This should be re-worded as 'management entity' which is consistent with the overall strategic Open Space strategy for the development.

- **Provision for Utilities Infrastructure**

  We reiterate our concern that there is no strategic approach to the provision of utilities, and we would welcome some indication of the principle of undergrounding of overhead wires (power and telephone) that currently cross the site and its neighbouring strategic open space.

Sylvia Brown, Vice Chair, South Marston Parish Council
Contact Clerk@southmarston.org.uk